

Beyond Recipients: A Framework for Meaningful Child Beneficiary Participation in Non-government Organizations

Maria Adiel H. Aguilung: ORCID 0009-0002-8779-3930

ABSTRACT

As the Sustainable Development Goals approach their final years, amplifying the voices of marginalized communities is paramount for inclusive development. This qualitative, multiple-case study sought to understand how child beneficiaries contribute to project management and what factors influence NGOs to engage in participation. A total of 52 respondents participated in the study, including six board trustees, eight managers, and 38 beneficiaries. The research on three NGOs identified four key antecedents of child beneficiary participation: 1) management's stakeholder perception of beneficiaries; 2) beneficiaries' self-perception as stakeholders; 3) the mutual trust between leaders and beneficiaries; and 4) a shared desire for beneficiary self-reliance. This study contributes to theory by providing a framework of meaningful participation of child beneficiaries in NGOs. While the findings do not allow for statistical generalization, they offer insights into participatory practices that may be relevant to other NGOs, particularly those operating in high-power distance cultures. It underscores the need for NGO leaders to critically examine their beliefs, values and perspectives, ultimately reinforcing that child beneficiaries are not merely recipients but active agents capable of shaping organizational outcomes.

Keywords: Child participation, beneficiary participation, SDG 10, Philippine NGOs

* Assistant professor, De La Salle University, Manila
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INTRODUCTION

As the Sustainable Development Goals agenda enters its final years, amplifying the voices of the marginalized is crucial for attaining inclusive development. A global shift from a top-down to a participatory approach underscores the recognition that local communities possess the most relevant insights into their circumstances (Cornwall, 2006; Mansuri & Rao, 2013). Ensuring that communities have ownership over their development programs is key to enhancing service efficiency, effectiveness, and long-term impact (Abdullahi et al., 2014; Cornwall, 2006; Mansuri & Rao, 2013).

While many non-government organizations (NGOs) were established to serve the needy, a critical question remains: do they genuinely engage with their beneficiaries to understand their needs? Empowering beneficiaries to influence the management of projects designed for them is often termed ‘beneficiary participation’ (Band’e, Ika, & Ou’edraogo, 2024; Mercelis et al. 2016; Wellens & Jegers, 2014a). Despite its importance, a theoretical gap persists in the literature, as most studies focus on fragmented factors rather than a holistic framework for understanding the drivers of participation.

Furthermore, an empirical gap exists in the research on indigenous NGOs, as existing studies focus on Western organizations or those with Western affiliations. This makes a localized study in the Philippine context particularly relevant, where a high-power distance culture often leads individuals to defer to authority, which can uniquely influence participatory dynamics (Hofstede et al. 2010; Hofstede, 2011).

To address these gaps, this study aims to develop an indigenous model of the antecedents of child beneficiary participation, providing insights that can enhance participatory practices and improve service delivery in NGOs. Specifically, the research addresses two key questions:

1. How do child beneficiaries contribute to the management of projects intended for them?
2. What factors influence NGOs to engage in child beneficiary participation?

REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE

Non-government Organizations in the Philippines

NGOs are non-stock, non-profit organizations registered with the Securities and Exchange Commission (Philippine Council for NGO Certification, 2021). They emerged in the 1970s to address public service gaps (Asian Development Bank, 2013) and promote democracy in the 1980s under President Corazon Aquino’s administration (ADB, 2013; Songco, 2007). Initially, NGOs relied heavily on foreign aid, but a decrease in international funding in the 1990s led to competition and a struggle to balance donor objectives with beneficiary needs (Carin˜o, 1999; Songco, 2007). In response, the sector established self-regulatory mechanisms. CODE-NGO created a Code of Conduct in 1991, and in 1998, the Philippine Council for NGO Certification (PCNC) was founded to accredit NGOs that meet standards for good governance (Philippine Council for NGO Certification, 2024). While PCNC certification offers tax benefits to local donors, it does not mandate beneficiary participation (Philippine Council for NGO Certification, 2025), a key aspect of good governance highlighted by experts (Aldaba, 2002; Garcia, 2022).

Beneficiary Participation

The concept of beneficiary participation is a central tenet in the literature on nonprofit management and development, though its definition is not without debate. One perspective defines participation primarily by the beneficiaries' influence on organizational decision-making and governance (Wellens & Jegers, 2011, 2016). Other scholars also emphasize beneficiaries' direct influence on the direction and implementation of projects intended for them (Paul, 1987; Aga et al., 2018). In contrast, another view interprets beneficiary participation more broadly, including any form of beneficiary contribution to a development project. This can range from providing money or labor (Aga et al., 2018; Akaba et al., 2021) to offering information, feedback, and insights (Aga et al., 2018; George et al., 2018; Kingston et al., 2020) without necessarily influencing organizational leaders' final decisions. To classify these levels, scholars have developed various typologies.

Arnstein's (1969) 'ladder of citizen participation' is a foundational model, categorizing engagement from 'non-participation' and 'tokenism' to 'citizen power.' Applying this framework to microenterprises, Bhatt (1997) identifies three types: 'non-participation,' where the poor are excluded; 'tokenism,' where they are given a mere semblance of involvement; and 'participation,' which genuinely enables communities to mobilize resources and make decisions

Some scholars simplify this spectrum into two primary forms: passive and genuine participation (Aga et al., 2018; Flint & Blyth, 2021). In 'passive participation', beneficiaries have limited influence, as project objectives are predetermined by the implementing organization. In contrast, 'genuine participation' involves beneficiaries in key decision-making processes (Aga et al., 2018; Flint & Blyth, 2021). This approach aligns with higher-level typologies like Arnstein's 'citizen power.' While genuine participation is widely advocated (Chu & Luke, 2018; Flint & Blyth, 2021; Kingston et al., 2010), some argue that it can be unwieldy and slow down projects (Brett, 2003).

Children Participation

The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) promotes the greater involvement of children in projects that affect them (Lansdown, 2014; United Nations, 2023). Influenced by Arnstein, Hart's (2008) 'ladder of participation' is a key framework for this field, though it was later criticized for its rigid and hierarchical nature. Inspired by Hart's framework, Shier (2001) creates an alternative, "pathways to participation," with five levels from children being "listened to" to "sharing power and responsibility." This model is a practical tool for organizations to improve engagement (Dillon, 2021). Similarly, Lansdown (2010) identifies three broad categories for meaningful participation. 'Consultative participation' involves adults initiating a process to seek children's perspectives to inform final decisions. 'Collaborative participation' builds on this by having adults and children work as partners, with children acting as co-decision-makers. The third category, 'child-led participation,' is where children identify their own concerns and lead projects, with adults serving as facilitators who empower children to take control of the process (Lansdown, 2014). Other scholars further define the key elements of meaningful participation in contexts such as residential care. Bouma et al. (2018) proposes a model for meaningful participation encompassing the components of informing, hearing, and involving (Slaatto, Baugerud, & Mellblom, 2024).

Literature on child participation generally favors the concept of ‘meaningful participation’ over ‘genuine participation.’ This focus recognizes children’s capacity to form and express their own views, which is seen as valuable even if they are not yet actively making final decisions, aligning with the core thrust of the UNCRC.

Beneficiaries as stakeholders

A stakeholder is any individual or group with an interest in an organization who can affect or be affected by its activities (Freeman, 2005; Pirozzi, 2019). In nonprofit organizations, which lack shareholders, key stakeholders include the board, funders, managers, and beneficiaries (Ebrahim, 2003; Wellens & Jegers, 2014b). Beneficiaries are a core group of stakeholders who gain from an organization’s projects and programs. Historically, the term ‘beneficiaries’ implies a passive role as mere recipients of aid. However, this terminology is criticized for suggesting a limited and passive form of participation (Flint & Blythe, 2021). Consequently, alternative terms are proposed to better reflect beneficiaries’ active roles. For instance, authors use ‘actors’ to emphasize their ability to influence outcomes, (Chambers, 1994), or ‘partners’ to highlight their collaboration and contribution to value creation (Chu, 2015; Trujillo, 2018). This perspective is rooted in the idea that beneficiaries have a fundamental right to be heard and participate in decisions that affect them (Alkire, 2010; Chu & Luke, 2022). Trujillo (2018) further asserts that beneficiaries can only become effective collaborators once they are empowered to solve their own problems and make their own decisions.

The perspective of organizational leaders on beneficiaries is a crucial factor that can either propel or hinder participation. As Bhatt (1997) concludes, a leader who perceives beneficiaries as unfit for rational participation will tend to design non-participatory programs. Conversely, leaders who believe in the capabilities of beneficiaries are more likely to engage them in genuine participation. This suggests that while beneficiaries are widely recognized as nonprofit stakeholders (Chu & Luke, 2022; Mercelis et al., 2016; Trujillo, 2018), the leaders’ perception of them significantly influences the level and quality of their participation.

Funding agency

Western literature underscores the push of donor agencies to execute beneficiary participation (LeRoux, 2009; Murtaza, 2012). Historically, Filipino NGOs are required to meet donor requirements, though beneficiary participation is not explicitly mandated (Carin˜o, 1999).

Trust

Trust is a key factor affecting beneficiary participation. A local study by Aguilung (2021) provided evidence that trust in the capacity of beneficiaries is an essential prerequisite for participation. This aligns with findings from Western literature that trust in the intellectual and social characteristics of beneficiaries is crucial for participation to take place (Bess et al., 2009; Mercelis et al., 2016). Considering the Filipino psyche (Lasquety-Reyes, 2017), it is culturally appropriate to consider how a leader’s trust in beneficiaries impacts participation (Aguilung, 2024).

FRAMEWORK

The research is developed and analyzed using an integrative framework of stakeholder theory, agency theory, and Sikolohiyang Pilipino.

Stakeholder Theory

Stakeholder Theory posits that an organization's actions affect, or could affect, individuals and groups who have a stake in its operations (Freeman, 2005). The theory emphasizes that organizations should listen to stakeholders, build strong relationships with them (Westermann-Behaylo et al., 2016), and foster collaboration among different groups (Freeman & Moutchnik, 2013). Despite potential conflicts of interest, proponents of the theory argue that effectively managing the needs and concerns of multiple stakeholders can lead to significant cooperative advantages (Strand & Freeman, 2015).

Over the years, various methods for classifying stakeholders have emerged. Some are based on a stakeholder's formal or contractual relationship with a company (Clarkson, 1995). Others use salience—a combination of power, legitimacy, and urgency (Mitchell, Agle & Wood, 1997)—or distinguish between customers who produce and those who consume (McGrath & Whitty, 2017).

Based on empirical research, Miles (2017) developed another classification system with four primary types:

Influencer: Can significantly help or harm the organization.

Claimant: Actively demands rights and interests from the organization.

Collaborator: Works with the organization but does not have a personal interest in influencing it. Recipient: A passive stakeholder who does not actively demand a claim.

Miles noted that these classifications are not mutually exclusive and can be combined to describe a single stakeholder group.

Agency Theory

Agency Theory explains the relationship between a principal and an agent (Lan & Heracleous, 2010). In a business setting, the board of directors acts as the principal while the manager serves as the agent. The theory assumes that while both parties aim to maximize their own satisfaction, their interests may not always align. This divergence, known as the agency problem, can lead to an agent's misbehavior if left unchecked. To mitigate this, the principal incurs agency costs to monitor the agent and align goals through incentives like compensation or governance structures (Lan & Heracleous, 2010; Van Puyvelde et al., 2012).

However, this theory requires reframing for nonprofit organizations due to key differences (Nikolova, 2014; Wellens & Jegers, 2014b). Unlike for-profits, nonprofits cannot simply use a pay-for-performance scheme because of their non-distribution constraint (Van Puyvelde et al., 2012). Additionally, identifying a single principal is difficult given the absence of corporate owners and shareholders (Nikolova, 2014).

For this reason, researchers suggest that nonprofits have multiple principals (Nikolova, 2014; Wellens & Jegers, 2014b). In this extended model, each stakeholder group—including donors, board members, government, employees, and beneficiaries—acts as a principal with a corresponding role in governance. It is in this context that beneficiaries are encouraged to share power in policy-making and governance, which can directly impact an organization's effectiveness (Wellens & Jegers, 2014b).

Sikolohiyang Pilipino

Sikolohiyang Pilipino (SP), or Filipino Psychology, is a psychological discipline developed from the experiences, thoughts, and cultural orientation of Filipinos, making full use of Filipino language and culture (Pe-Pua & Protacio-Marcelina, 2000). It is a research movement that uses a local perspective to ensure that findings are culturally relevant and applicable to the people concerned (Clemente, 2011). As a discipline, SP develops frameworks, methods, and tools that are culturally relevant (Paredes-Canilao & Babaran-Diaz, 2013), often using a phenomenological-interpretative approach combined with a close study of local languages as clues to a people's culture (Paredes-Canilao & Babaran-Diaz, 2013). SP uses indigenous research methods that are inherently participatory and collaborative. One of these is *pagtatanong-tanong*, which translates to 'questioning-asking questions.' This method is characterized by its participatory nature, an emphasis on equality between the researcher and the informant, and its adaptability to the community's specific conditions (Pe-Pua, 1989;2005).

Another key method is *pakikipagkuwentuhan*, or 'story-telling.' Through this method, informants or groups of informants freely and informally share their beliefs and experiences, engaging in an exchange of opinions (Pe-Pua, 2005). These methods highlight SP's focus on reciprocal relationships and a shared process of knowledge creation, which are crucial concepts for understanding a meaningful participation within a Filipino context (Aguiling, 2024).

RESEARCH PHILOSOPHY

This study adopts an interpretivist research philosophy, which aligns with the SP approach (Paredes-Canilao & Babaran-Diaz, 2013). Interpretivism is founded on the belief that reality is socially constructed through culture and language and that a single phenomenon can have multiple, subjective interpretations (Saunders et al., 2019). Knowledge is therefore gained through narratives, stories, and individual perceptions.

This philosophy is particularly relevant to the study of Filipino concepts because it avoids the positivist inclination toward universal laws and generalizations, which SP criticizes (Paredes-Canilao & Babaran-Diaz, 2013). By adopting an interpretivist stance, this research seeks to capture the unique meaning of each key informant's perceptions, actions, and understanding, which complements SP's purpose of analyzing the experiences of both elite and non-elite Filipinos.

Conceptual Framework

This study's conceptual framework serves as a working model to guide the research. It proposes that an NGO's engagement in child beneficiary participation is influenced by the following antecedents: the board's and management's classification of beneficiaries, the beneficiaries' self-perceived classification, the level of trust in beneficiaries, and the influence of funding

agencies. These constructs are derived from stakeholder and agency theories, as well as literature. An interpretivist study aims to generate, rather than verify, theory (Cresswell, 2009). Nonetheless, such studies may lay down propositions to guide its inquiry (Gioia et al., 2013)

Proposition 1: The board's perceived stakeholder classification of beneficiaries influences the NGO's engagement in beneficiary participation.

As the board of trustees holds the principal governing position within an NGO, its perception of beneficiaries directly shapes its governance and dictates the mandate for beneficiary engagement. Drawing on Miles' (2012) stakeholder classification, when NGO leaders perceive beneficiaries as influencers, claimants, or collaborators and not as mere recipients, they are more likely to foster participation.

Proposition 2: The managers' perceived stakeholder classification of beneficiaries influences the NGO's engagement in beneficiary participation.

Drawing on Agency Theory, it is proposed that the perceptions of managers, who serve as on-the-ground leaders, can diverge from those of the board of trustees. Because they operate as separate agents within the organization, their views on beneficiaries independently influence their engagement and decision-making. Therefore, the managers' perceived stakeholder classification of beneficiaries will also impact the NGO's level of participation.

Proposition 3: The beneficiaries' perceived stakeholder classification of themselves does not affect the NGO's engagement in beneficiary participation.

Building on power-distance theory (Hofstede et al., 2010), it is posited that beneficiaries in this cultural context, often defer to superiors and abide by their decisions. Consequently, the beneficiaries' own perceptions of their stakeholder role may not directly influence an NGO's level of engagement in beneficiary participation.

Proposition 4: The NGO leaders' trust in beneficiaries influences the practice of beneficiary participation.

Based on a local pilot study and existing Western literature, trust in beneficiaries' capacity is a key factor influencing their participation (Aguiling, 2021). In the context of Filipino psychology, however, the concept of trust extends beyond 'capacity' and encompasses an overall trust in another person, which is built through social interaction (Pe-Pua, 2005). Therefore, the study proposes that the overall trust NGO leaders have in beneficiaries, developed through social interaction, is a determinant of the level of beneficiary participation.

Proposition 5: Funding agencies influence the practice of beneficiary participation.

Building on existing literature that highlights the influence of donors on NGOs (Aldaba, 2002; Carin˜o, 1999; Aguiling, 2021), it is proposed that funding agencies affect the practice of beneficiary participation.

METHODOLOGY

This study utilized a qualitative research approach in the form of multiple-case study to generate rich, in-depth data for analysis and theory-building on child beneficiary participation in NGOs (Merriam, 1998). Employing an explanatory case study through an interpretivist lens, the researcher inductively gathered the experiences, perspectives, and voices of key informants (Saunders et al., 2019) in each case and analysed the factors driving children's participation in every case and across cases. Case Selection Cases were selected through purposive sampling, specifically a theorydriven and concept-based sampling strategy, to identify exemplary instances of the phenomenon under investigation (Quinn Patton, 2015). The chosen NGOs met the following criteria:

A social development NGO officially registered with the Philippine Securities and Exchange Commission for more than 20 years.

Fewer than 50 personnel.

Manages various social projects.

Actively engages in the participation of young beneficiaries.

DATA COLLECTION

Permission was obtained from the directors of three NGOs to participate in the study. The selected NGOs are:

NGO-A: Facilitates access to basic education for underprivileged children and engages their families and communities to support their intellectual, social, and moral development.

NGO-B: Aims to rebuild the lives of vulnerable children who have suffered neglect or cruelty, with a flagship program providing residential care for girls traumatized by exploitation and abandonment.

NGO-C: Empowers children, youth, families, and communities to prevent and respond to child abuse, managing a residential care facility for those in need of protection, including street children and survivors of abuse.

The key informants who participated in the study are summarized in Table 1.

Table 1: Key informants

Collection Method / Key informants	Case A: NGO-A	Case B: NGO-B	Case C: NGO-C
Semi-structured interviews			
Board	2	2 (1 is also Program Manager)	2
NGO managers /facilitators	4	2 (aside from the Program Manager)	2
<i>Pagtatanong-tanong & Pakikipagkuwentuhan</i>			
Beneficiaries: youth	8	10	10
Beneficiaries: parent leaders	3		
Former beneficiaries	5	2	
Total Number of Key informants per NGO	22	16	14
TOTAL NUMBER OF KEY INFORMANTS	52		

Source: Author's own

A total of 52 respondents participated in the study, including six board trustees, eight managers, and 38 beneficiaries. For primary data collection, semi-structured interviews were conducted with the board trustees and managers. To gather insights from beneficiaries, the researcher used pagtatanong-tanong and pakikipagkuwentuhan methods (Enriquez, 1978) to ensure culturally sensitive and contextually relevant data collection.

Data Analysis

The analysis applied Lansdown's (2010, 2014) child participation typology to determine the categories of participation observed. To analyze the antecedents of this participation, the study used the aforementioned conceptual framework based on existing literature. Miles' (2017) stakeholder classification framework was used to categorize stakeholders as influencers, collaborators, claimants, or recipients.

The researcher moved from specific observations to broader generalizations, focusing on individual cases while remaining open to analytical generalizations that could apply to other contexts (Stake, 2013). The data were coded using Gioia's methodology (Langley & Abdallah, 2011).

A cross-case synthesis was conducted to identify and match patterns within individual cases to patterns observed across all cases. To ensure the study's internal validity (Merriam, 1998), the research employed triangulation, member checks, and disclosure of researcher bias. External validity was strengthened through thick descriptions, multiple case comparisons, and the categorization of findings into aggregate dimensions. Reliability was enhanced by using data source triangulation, theory triangulation, an explanation of the researcher's position in relation to the study, and a consistent case study protocol (Stake, 1995).

The research followed the Velez College Ethics Review Committee's guidelines and protocols, and obtained informed consent from all participants.

KEY FINDINGS

Beneficiary Participation in NGOs

This study examined the practice of beneficiary participation in three NGOs serving children.

NGO-A facilitates beneficiary participation through two main programs: Catch-up and Organizing Children. In the Catch-up program, children and youth serve as Junior Educators, tutoring other children, while their tutees provide feedback by evaluating the activity. The Organizing Children program forms a Barangay Children Association (BCA) whose officers plan and lead activities based on member concerns. These officers also develop advocacy campaigns, such as against early marriages, and their representatives participate in dialogues with national bodies. NGO-A uses consultative, collaborative, and child-led approaches in participatory mechanisms.

NGO-B's managers engage the girls in operating their residential home. The girls develop themselves and contribute to their own healing and recovery by leading other children and communities. They participate in planning house assignments, evaluating their own engagement, and meeting to solve problems. The girls also plan and conduct advocacy campaigns against child trafficking in schools and communities. The NGO's beneficiaries participate in mechanisms that are categorized as consultative, collaborative, and child-led initiatives. NGO-C involves children in making their shelter a home by forming Children's Councils where officers conduct meetings and advocate for children's rights. The Council provides a space for shy children to voice opinions and suggestions. Some boys work with adults to plan and manage a farm, handling budgeting and monitoring to learn practical life skills. The management also holds quarterly meetings to discuss topics and solicit ideas from children on how to address concerns. Annually, children from all shelters gather to hear the Children's Council's report, evaluate programs, and propose new initiatives. The NGO employs mechanisms that use consultative, collaborative, and child-led participation.

Table 2: Participatory mechanisms in NGOs

Participatory Mechanisms	Category of Participation (Lansdown, 2014)	Proportion of beneficiaries who participate
NGO-A		
Program: Catch-up		
Needs Assessment Survey	Consultative	Before lockdown: all tutees During lockdown: half of the tutees
Tutorials (of other children)	Child-led	Before lockdown: all Junior Educators During lockdown: no data
Evaluation of activities	Consultative	Nearly all Junior Educators
Program: Organizing Children		
Barangay Children Association	Consultative, Child-led	*Nearly all officers and members
BCA Sessions/Meetings	Child-led	Nearly all officers
BCA Cluster Meetings	Collaborative	*Nearly all officers and members
BCA General Assembly	Collaborative	*Nearly all officers and members

Participatory Mechanisms	Category of Participation (Lansdown, 2014)	Proportion of beneficiaries who participate
NGO-A		
Program: Catch-up		
Advocacy campaign	Collaborative	Half of the officers
Consultation with national bodies	Consultative, Collaborative, Child-led	Less than half of the officers
NGO -B		
House assignments	Consultative	All
Monthly meetings	Collaborative	All
Quarterly meetings	Collaborative	All
Program committees	Consultative, Collaborative, Child-led	All
Food preparation	Collaborative	All
Youth helping youth	Child-led	All
Child Advocates (dialogue with national bodies)	Child-led, Consultative	Half of the girls
NGO-C		
Tasks	Consultative	All
House meetings	Consultative	*Nearly all children in each shelter
Children Council	Collaborative, Child-led	All officers
Quarterly assembly	Collaborative	*Nearly all children in each shelter
General assembly	Consultative	*Nearly all children in the shelters
Advocacy Campaigns	Consultative	More than half of the officers
Consultation with national bodies	Child-led, Consultative	More than half of the officers
Social Enterprise	Collaborative, Child-led	*Nearly all in a shelter

Source: Author's own

*All children are invited. Although not everyone comes, nearly all attend and participate.

Perception on the Stakeholder Classification of Child Beneficiaries

Board Trustees

The board trustees' perceptions of beneficiaries varied across and within organizations. At NGO-A, one trustee viewed children as partners, while another saw them as pure recipients. Trustee A1 highlighted the children's inherent dignity and right to participate as human beings. At NGO-B, Trustee B1 did not believe children could contribute to decision-making. However, Trustee B2—who also serves as a program manager—perceived the children as partners, contributors, and ambassadors, asserting that they would not thrive in the program by merely following instructions. Both trustees at NGO-C shared the belief that children are not just recipients but active participants.

Management

The managers' perceptions were more consistent. The four managers at NGO-A unanimously viewed children as partners whose participation is vital to the program's success. At NGO-B, managers saw the girls as collaborators in their own development and the organization's mission, believing in the inherent goodness of each person. The managers relied on the girls' insights and help to organize the home and execute advocacy campaigns. Similarly, the Executive Director of NGO-C stressed that they do not use the terms 'recipients' or 'beneficiaries.' Instead, they refer to the youth as 'children' with rights and duties. The house manager reinforced this view by seeing the youth as her own children, or anak.

Beneficiaries

Beneficiaries also viewed themselves as active contributors. At NGO-A, one child perceived themselves as a leader working directly with the director and social workers, while others saw themselves as the 'hope of the community' and 'role models' who bridged the gap between adults and children. At NGO-B, children saw themselves as partners, with one noting they needed to contribute to the organization and not always rely on their managers. The beneficiaries at NGO-C expressed a family-like bond, with the boys seeing themselves as anak and the girls perceiving themselves as leaders who assisted staff.

Funding agency

The influence of funding agencies on beneficiary participation was limited. At NGO-A, participation was driven by internal initiatives, not donor requirements. NGO-B had already been practicing beneficiary participation before seeking donations, though donor inquiries on involvement prompted them to explore new mechanisms. NGO-C stressed that its participation mechanisms were established before they began working with funders.

Trust

Trust was a crucial factor. NGO-A Trustee A1 expressed trust in the children's words and actions. The management and social workers worked to understand each child's conditions and empowered them to participate once they were ready. The nuns at NGO-B practiced a 'preventive system' of loving kindness, reason, and religion to build trust with traumatized children. Their patience and guidance helped the children regain confidence. The beneficiaries expressed feeling their love, understanding, and acceptance. Child B1 expressed that she did not want to participate at the beginning but eventually collaborated because of the nuns' kindness and trust in her. The director of NGO-C trusted that everything the children said was valid and could not be neglected. The youth expressed their own confidence and trust in the adults, feeling they were part of a complete family. Child C1 confirmed that the managers and house parents provide a love they had never experienced before. He explained that they learned so much from the adults that they could not disregard what they say.

Other factors affecting beneficiary participation

Desire for child beneficiaries' self-reliance

A consistent finding across the NGOs was the desire to foster self-reliance among beneficiaries. Trustee A1 and management of NGO-A emphasized that they want individuals, families, and communities to be self-sustainable. As Manager A1 stated, the NGO's role is to contribute to improvement, but the beneficiaries are the true agents of their own change. This is rooted in the belief that the organization will not be present forever and that the children and their families must be able to continue these initiatives on their own.

At NGO-B, the program manager explained that the girls must develop skills and become productive to be successfully reintegrated into the community. Manager B1's motivation to engage the girls was fueled by this objective. She said, "This is just a temporary house for them. Hopefully, they will learn a lot, they become self-sufficient, self-reliant, and that they can stand on their own feet. Thereafter, they can protect themselves in case something happens."

NGO-C offers an Independent Living Skills Program to prepare the children for independent living or reintegration with their families. This program provides vocational training, assists with educational scholarships, and includes modules on topics like personality development and career preparedness. The children are also guided to follow a schedule and complete chores like planting and feeding animals to develop discipline.

Legislation on Children's Rights

The role of legislation in promoting children's participation varied among the NGOs. The Executive Director of NGO-A noted that their programs' emphasis on community participation was a natural extension of the social workers' background. However, they acknowledged that the Philippines' status as a signatory to the UNCRC strengthened their commitment to children's participation. The NGO follows specific laws, such as the Child Protection Program, and sends children to dialogues with the Civil Society Coalition on the Convention on the Rights of the Child.

In contrast, NGO-B's program manager stated that participation is fundamentally a part of their mission and that they would not consider the UNCRC as the reason for their practices, even though they adhere to national and local children's rights laws. Similarly, NGO-C sends child delegates to participate in discussions on children's issues but clarified that they have been engaging in child participation even before these laws were created and would continue to do so regardless of legal requirements.

DISCUSSION

Children Participation in NGOs The three NGOs in this study implemented similar participatory mechanisms, despite using slightly different terminology. Across all cases, child beneficiaries participated through common mechanisms summarized in Table 3.

Table 3: Common Participatory Mechanisms

Participatory Mechanisms	Description
Meetings/Assemblies	A venue for children to convene and express their needs, opinions, and feedback on activities.
Committees/Associations	Children's membership in groups that organize and manage events within the NGO.
Teaching/Training	Platforms where children transfer knowledge and share values with other youth through initiatives like advocacy campaigns.
Consultation and Dialogues	National forums where children represent the NGO and engage with authorities on their concerns.

Source: Author's own

All three NGOs employed different mechanisms across varied categories of participation, but they converged on using all three approaches from Lansdown's (2014) typology: 'consultative', 'collaborative', and 'child-led' participation. This indicates that each NGO engages children in meaningful ways, and that these levels are not mutually exclusive. For example, NGO-A managers consult with BCA officers, who then manage the activities with adult facilitators providing guidance.

Another common feature across the NGOs is the provision of opportunities for all children to participate. While some mechanisms are specific to officers or representatives, like NGO-A's BCA meetings and NGO-C's Children's Council, other mechanisms ensure that managers solicit input and collaboration from all children -officers and non-officers- in their programs.

Antecedents of Child Beneficiary Participation

A shared set of core beliefs serves as the foundation for beneficiary participation across all three NGOs. These organizations consistently treated children as individuals with rights, worthy of respect, which was manifested by NGO-A's emphasis on inherent dignity, NGO-B's belief in the 'seed of goodness' within each child, and NGO-C's view of the youth as anak (their own sons and daughters). This fundamental belief was buttressed by a deeply ingrained value for the practice of participation itself, as all three NGOs believed in the children's ability to influence the design, operations, and evaluation of projects for success.

A cross-case analysis revealed four primary antecedents of beneficiary participation shared among the NGOs:

Management's Perceived Stakeholder Classification of Child Beneficiaries

A primary antecedent revealed through the analysis is the management's perception of beneficiaries as stakeholders. The NGOs consistently viewed the children not as passive recipients but as partners, ambassadors, or collaborators. This perception, which aligns with Miles' (2017) classification, motivated leaders to actively listen to children's insights, collaborate with them, and afford them the autonomy to execute initiatives. This finding supports Proposition 2.

Beneficiaries' Self-Perceived Stakeholder Classification

A second key antecedent is the beneficiaries' own self-perception. The youth saw themselves as leaders, role models, and partners, rather than as passive recipients, influencers, or claimants. Contrary to Proposition 3, this self-perception as collaborators propelled their active cooperation with management.

Mutual Trust

A third factor is the mutual trust between management and beneficiaries. The trust process was initiated by NGO leaders, and their confidence in beneficiaries encouraged engagement in participatory mechanisms. This was moderated by the beneficiaries' trust in the leadership, which in turn strengthened or weakened the impact of the leaders' trust on their participation. This finding supports Proposition 4.

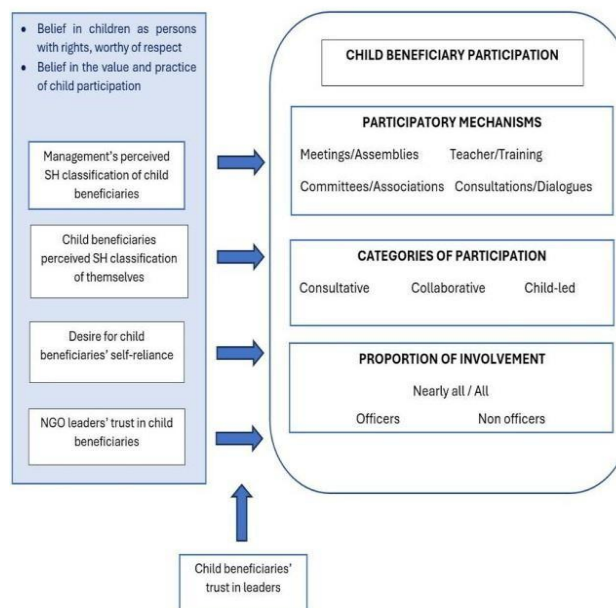
Desire for Beneficiary Self-Reliance

A fourth significant factor is the NGO leaders' strong desire to foster beneficiary self-reliance. To promote autonomy and independence, NGOs deliberately engage the children in participatory activities, character development, and skills training to equip them for their future after they leave the care of the organization.

Conversely, the findings did not consistently support the influence of board trustees' perceptions (Proposition 1), as not all trustees believed in the children's capacity for participation. Likewise, there was no solid evidence supporting the role of funding agencies (Proposition 4). Importantly, while the NGOs do not consider the UNCRC as the primary driver of their practices, the convention and other related laws provide a legal basis and structured opportunities for children's participation.

Based on these findings, Figure 1 presents a framework for a meaningful child beneficiary participation. It illustrates how the core beliefs of the NGOs, combined with key antecedent factors, lead to the observed mechanisms, involvement, and types of meaningful child beneficiary participation.

Figure 1: A Framework of Meaningful Child Beneficiary Participation in Philippine NGOs



Source: Author's own

CONCLUSION

The final years of the Sustainable Development Goals have brought a renewed focus on empowering marginalized populations to ensure inclusive growth and lasting change. This study affirms that the active participation of child beneficiaries is a powerful mechanism for fostering social inclusion and reducing systemic inequalities.

Through a qualitative case study of three NGOs in the Philippines, this research reveals the existence of meaningful child participation through consultative, collaborative, and child-led approaches. While some mechanisms are reserved for child leaders, the organizations obtain the participation of nearly all or all children to express their views, work alongside adults, and contribute to decision-making.

The study's primary contribution to theory is its development of an indigenous framework identifying the key antecedents of beneficiary participation in a specific, high-power distance cultural context. While the findings are not statistically generalizable, they offer valuable insights into participatory practices that can be applied to other NGOs.

This research challenges the conventional view of project management by providing empirical evidence of children's agency. The findings reinforce that child beneficiaries are not merely recipients of aid but active agents capable of shaping service

delivery and organizational outcomes. Ultimately, this study underscores the need for NGOs to critically examine their foundational beliefs, values, and perceptions toward beneficiaries.

It is recommended that this framework be used to guide future research on child beneficiary participation, particularly in high-power distance cultures, to further promote meaningful children's participation.

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